The Next Family Call About Your Father

How to talk about what's going wrong, one problem at a time.

The last call about your father started with his missed appointment and ended with who did what at Christmas. Everyone has a theory, your sister is worn out, and nobody can say exactly what is going wrong.

This guide is for one call with one job: take the problems one at a time and write down what each person sees. It isn't for settling who is right, and it isn't for deciding anything about his care.

Who should be on the call

Your father, if he wants to be there. The Family Caregiver Alliance points out that family members usually don't want to be left out, and that their preferences for care must be considered. Then your sister, who does most of the day-to-day, and everyone else who helps or may be asked to, which can include a friend, a neighbor or a paid caregiver. Someone who can't join can send a few lines ahead. [1]

Send around a short agenda beforehand, naming the problems you'd like to cover. The same guide says a narrow focus for each meeting helps. [1]

Ask one person to keep the notes, someone other than whoever is running the call.

How to open

Say what the call is for before anyone says what's wrong. Then start with the two people closest to it.

The National Institute on Aging suggests that relatives who aren't the primary caregiver acknowledge how important that person is, and ask what would be most helpful. [2]

It can also help to agree on one habit for the call. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests saying “I need” in place of “you should.” [1]

- To everyone: “I'd like us to take one problem at a time tonight and write down what each of us has seen. We don't have to agree.”
- To your father: “We'd like to hear from you first. How are things going, from where you sit?”
- To your sister: “You see more of this than the rest of us. I'd like to hear what it's like for you before anyone suggests anything.”
- Name the first problem as something that happened: “He missed his appointment on Tuesday, and none of us knew until Thursday.”

Questions to ask

Ask your father

1. What is working for you at the moment, and what isn't?

Ask your sister

1. What help do you need now?

2. Which tasks can't go on the way they are?

Ask each other, about one problem at a time

1. What actually happened, and when?

2. What isn't getting done because of it?

3. Who here saw it differently, and what did you see?

4. What do we still need to find out, and who would know?

5. Is this one for us to sort out, or for someone outside the family?

How to write down what was said

Stay on one problem until everyone has spoken, then move to the next. Where two people remember it differently, write both and leave both. Concerns that belong together can share a heading.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	SEEN DIFFERENTLY BY	STILL TO FIND OUT
“He missed Tuesday's appointment and I didn't hear until Thursday.”	You		Who had the date written down
“I thought the ride was arranged.”	Your brother	Your sister remembers that nobody had settled it	

What not to decide on this call

Leave these four open. A family call can't settle them, and all but the first belong with the people who assess him. Write them on the open list and move on.

- Whose fault any of it is.
- Whether your father is safe where he is.
- Whether he should move, or have more help.
- Anything about his medications or treatment.

What you can agree on before you hang up

- Which problems you covered, and which stay on the open list for next time.
- Who will send the notes to everyone.
- Who will take each outside question to the doctor's office, the nurse, the pharmacist or your care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

You won't get through everything on one call, and you don't have to. The Family Caregiver Alliance says it will probably be difficult to cover every issue in one meeting, and that a family meeting is not a one-time event. [1]

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, decide anything about your father's care, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets one problem at a time onto paper, with the differences left in.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has talked about one problem at a time and written down where you see it differently. The care interview takes it from there: it goes through your father's situation area by area, including the parts nobody raised on the call, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers